

Let It Lie

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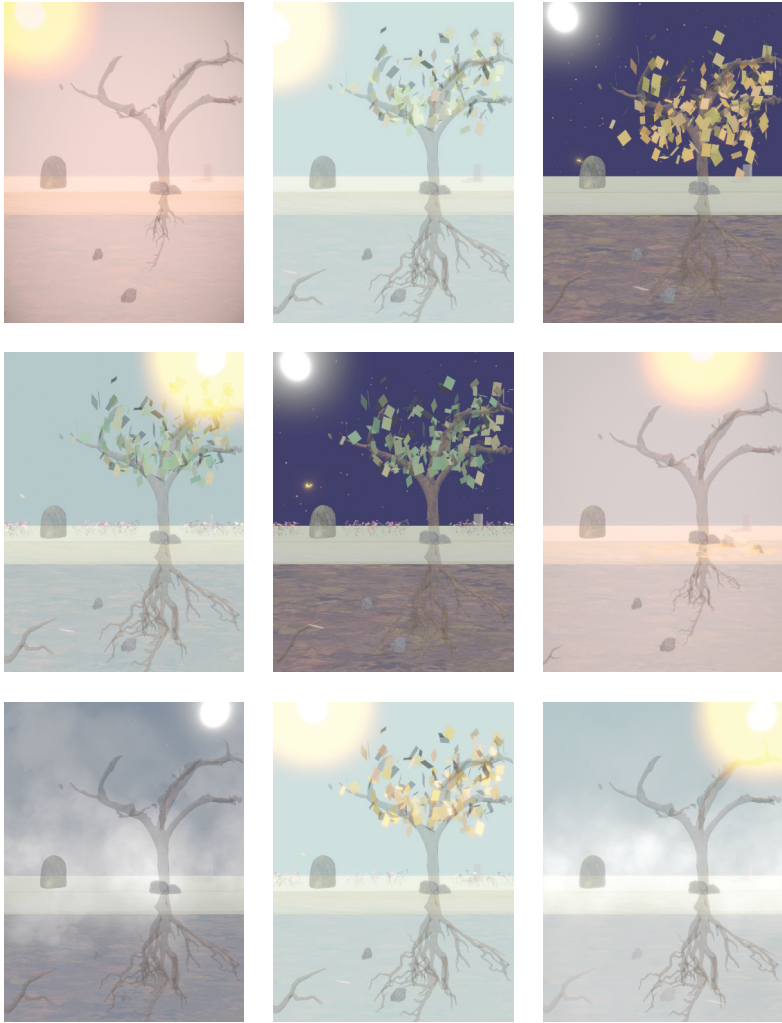
Hans is the gardener of the « Cimetière des Rois ». Day after day, season after season, he repeats the same rituals of care. Convinced that caring means acting, he tirelessly tends the cemetery, keeping death at bay.

Yet the cemetery follows its own rhythms. Leaves become humus, roots spread beneath the soil, moss grows on stone, and life emerges from decay. As the seasons unfold, Hans begins to notice that every action alters a cycle that does not depend on him.

In Let It Lie, players accompany Hans through four seasons and eight day-and-night cycles. Gifted with the power to influence the weather and the living world, they may act upon the environment at any moment. But every intervention carries consequences, raising the same question again and again: does this moment call for action, or simply for presence?

What if the most caring thing to do is sometimes to let things follow their own course. To let it lie?





The cemetery across the seasons.



One summer morning.

User Journey

As Hans, the player moves through a seasonal loop spanning four seasons and eight day-and-night cycles. Along the way, they observe the evolution of the cemetery and may choose to intervene in natural cycles or let them unfold on their own.

Their actions affect the ecosystem and subsequent cycles. As the seasons pass, the player gradually discovers that not every situation calls for intervention.

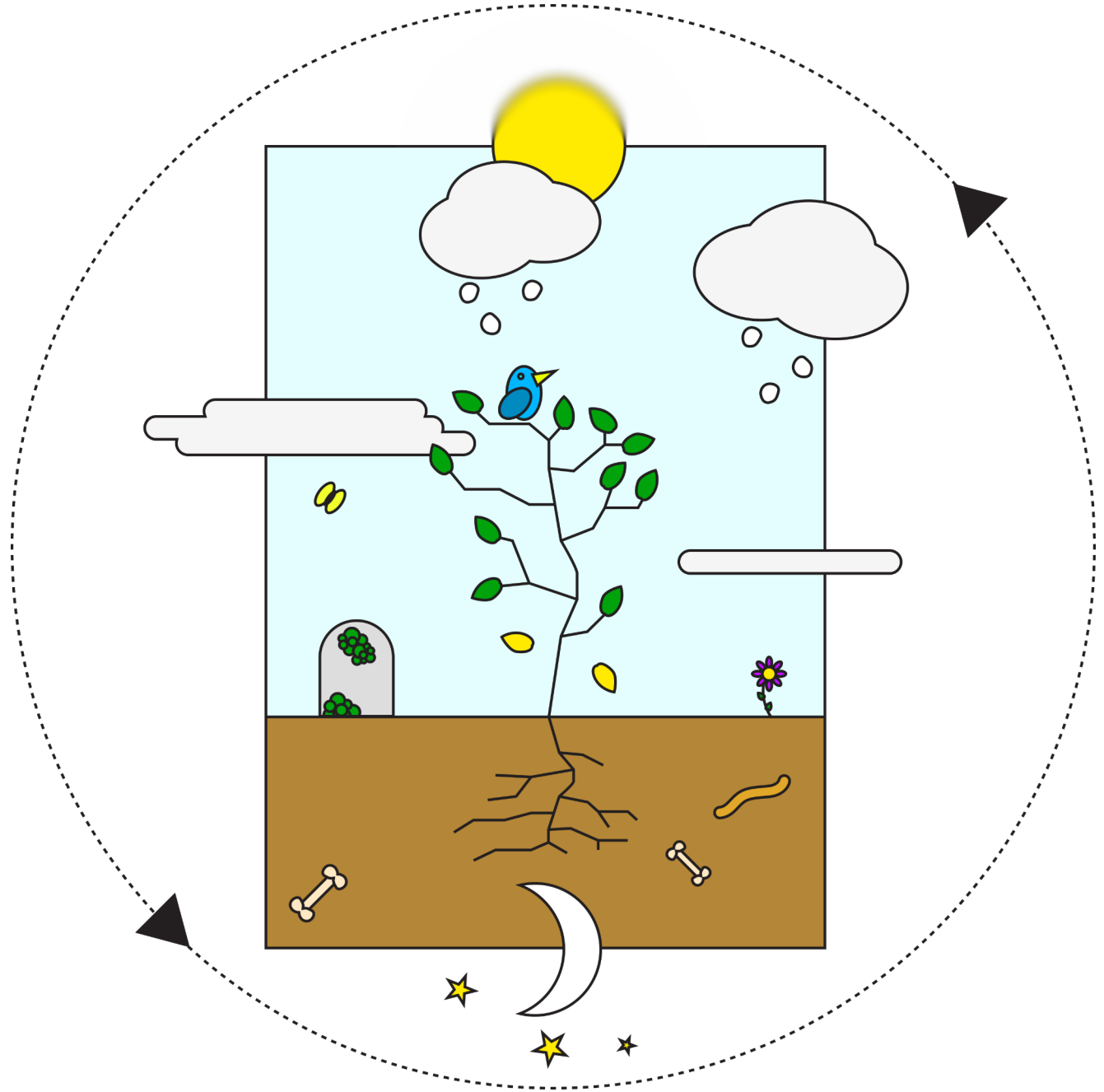
The experience explores the tension between acting and letting be.

Key interactions

1. **Hold** Accelerate time
2. **Click** Collect elements
3. **Drag** Create wind

4 Seasons 2 Cycles

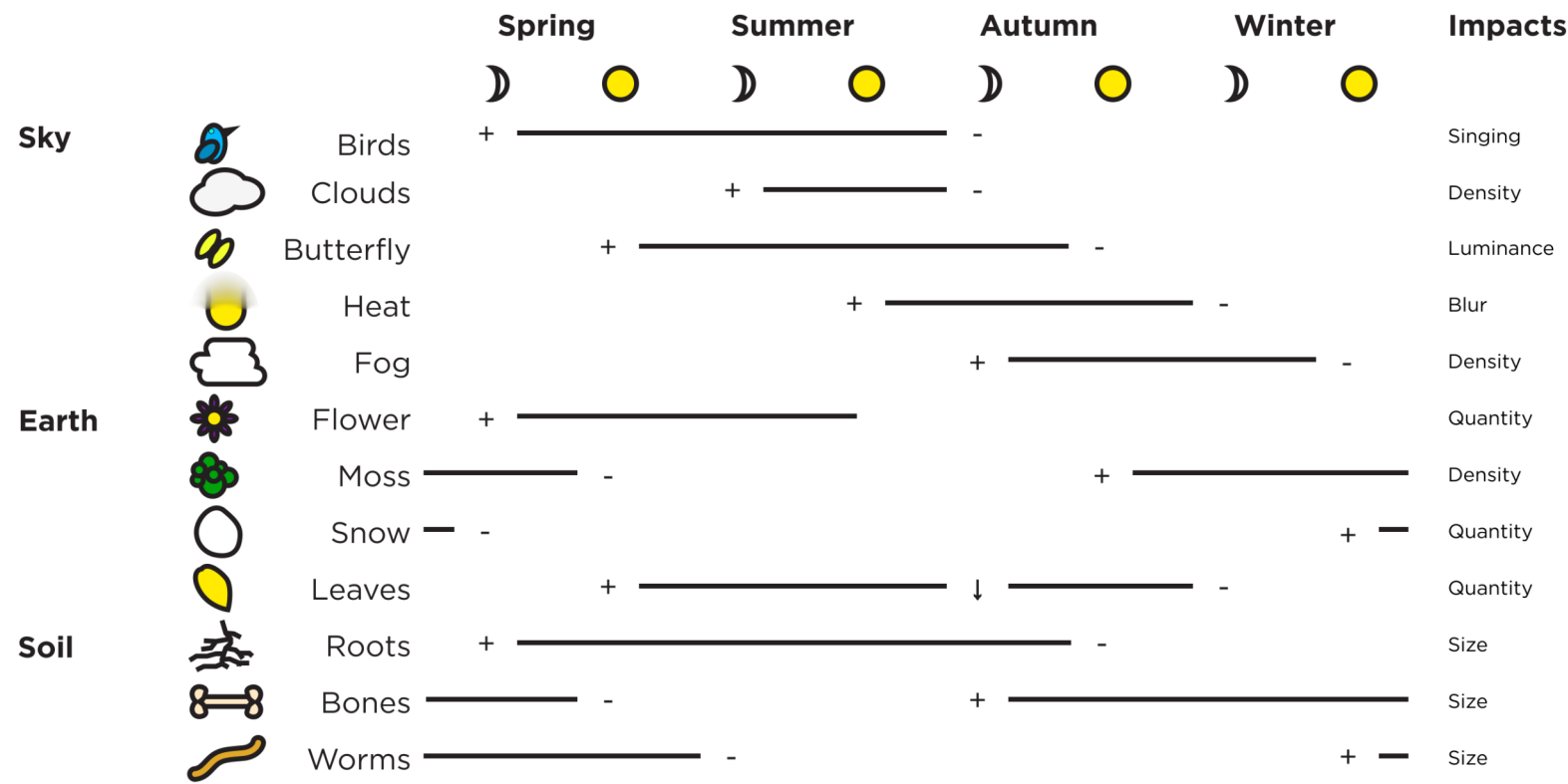
Spring	[☾ - ☀]
Summer	[☾ - ☀]
Autumn	[☾ - ☀]
Winter	[☾ - ☀]



Timeline

The timeline maps the cycles of natural phenomena throughout the year, showing how they emerge, transform, and disappear across the cemetery's different layers.

It also highlights the impact of the player's actions on the ecosystem.



Final Production

List of features and elements that could be added to the final version, ordered by priority.

Estimated time 6.5 workday

Step	Type	Description	Estimated time (days)
Refactoring	Global	Code stabilization and cleanup	1
Hans's thread	Scenography	With the scenographer: connect the thread to the tablet	0.25
Cimetière des Rois	Assets	Modify the tree and add tombs that more closely resemble the « Cimetière des Rois »	0.5
Voice feedback	Audio	Verena and Guillem's voices provide contextual feedback on the ecological consequences of the player's actions	1
Kankyō Ongaku	Audio	Evolving environmental ambient soundtrack	1
Collecting	Interaction	Gestures and behavior related to the act of collecting	0.5
Dream effect	Effect	Enhance the « Dream » effect with a shader in post-processing	0.25
Birds	Asset	React to the health of the environment (sing more or less)	0.25
Moss	Interaction	Regrows on gravestones during autumn	0.5
Bones	Asset	React to soil quality	0.25
Clouds	Effect	Springtime clouds	0.25
Heat	Effect	Add a blur/humidity effect during summer	0.25
Snow	Effect	Falls during winter	0.25
Icon + Splash Screen	Global	Visual assets	0.25

Field Research

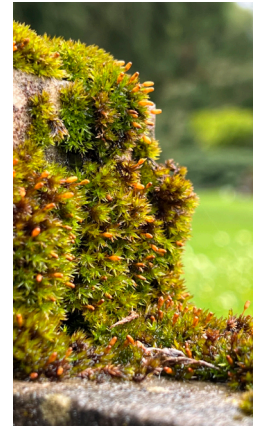
Let It Lie emerged from a series of readings, observations, and conversations with gardeners and landscape architects around Geneva's « Cimetière des Rois ».

What initially appeared as a place dedicated to death gradually revealed itself as a living ecosystem. Leaves decompose into humus, moss colonizes gravestones, roots spread beneath monuments, insects and birds inhabit the site, and bodies slowly return to the earth. Caring for such a place involves more than maintenance; it requires an understanding of the cycles that connect life, death, decay, and regeneration.

These encounters led us to reconsider the notion of care itself. Care is not only about acting, repairing, or preserving. It can also mean paying attention, making space, and allowing life to continue its own cycles.

References

1. Rossel, P. (1992). Une visite du cimetière de Plainpalais. Les Iles Futures.
2. Yalom, I. (2015). Le Jardin d'Épicure. Le Livre de Poche.
3. Guillaumont, N., Berthod, M.-A. (2024). Renouveler le paysage funéraire. <https://acrobat.adobe.com/id/urn:aaid:sc:EU:d9c1b3d7-d273-48c9-b190-6123cce73fd8>
4. Fleury, C. (2018). Ethique du Care [Vidéo]. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RQF6s8NgeLU>
5. Verena. (2026). Entretien au cimetière des Rois.
6. Guillem. (2026). Entretien téléphonique.



Stories & anecdotes

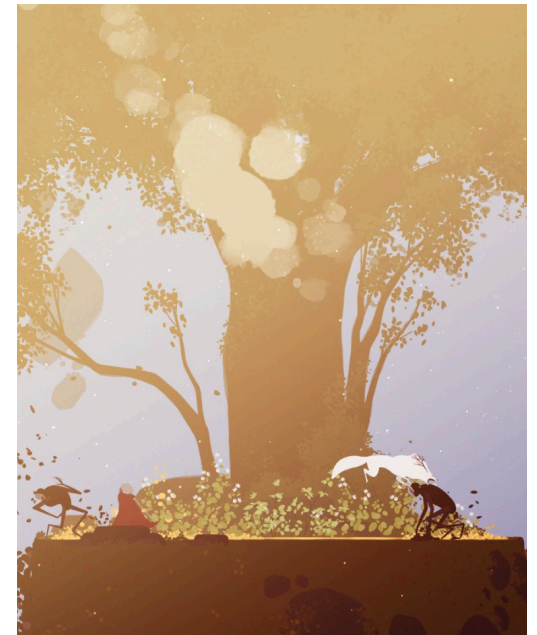
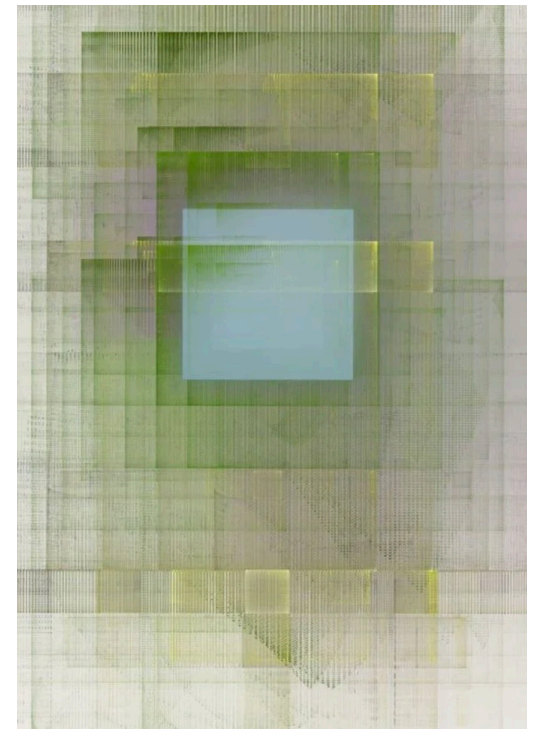
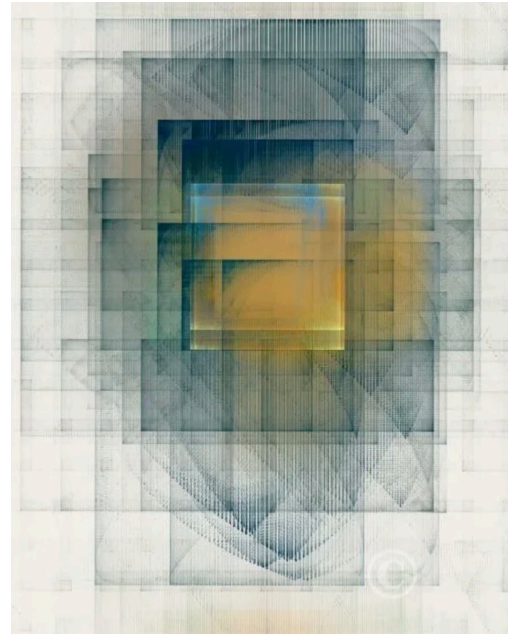
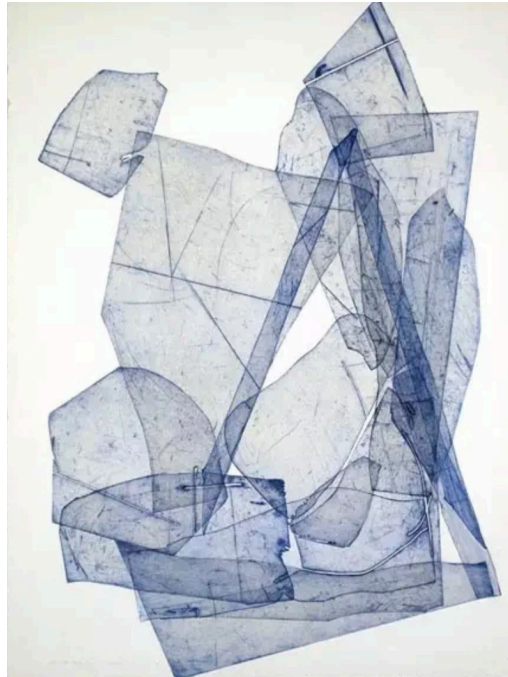
Selected anecdotes collected during interviews with gardeners and landscape professionals.



1. **Rare mosses** grow on some gravestones. These tiny ecosystems are protected and often thrive on non-native stone. Ironically, the more a grave is cleaned, the faster the moss tends to return.
2. In some beliefs, **cedar trees** are considered gateways between the world of the living and the world of the dead. The Cimetière des Rois is home to many of them.
3. In some cemeteries, **clay-rich soils** can slow decomposition so much that bodies remain intact for decades. Healthy soils depend on microorganisms, insects, and organic matter to sustain the cycle of life and decay.
4. Each spring, parts of the cemetery are left wild while **narrow paths** are mown through the grass. These temporary meadows create habitats for insects and transform the cemetery into a dreamlike landscape.
5. A dying tree in the Cimetière des Rois is being **covered with ivy** instead of being cut down. By allowing another plant to grow around it, the gardeners hope to extend its presence in the landscape.

Art Direction

Inspired by memory and remembrance, **Let It Lie** uses transparency to evoke the blurred and dreamlike nature of recollection. Simplified forms and translucent materials create an atmosphere suspended between presence and absence, where life, decay, and memory coexist within the «Cimetière des Rois».



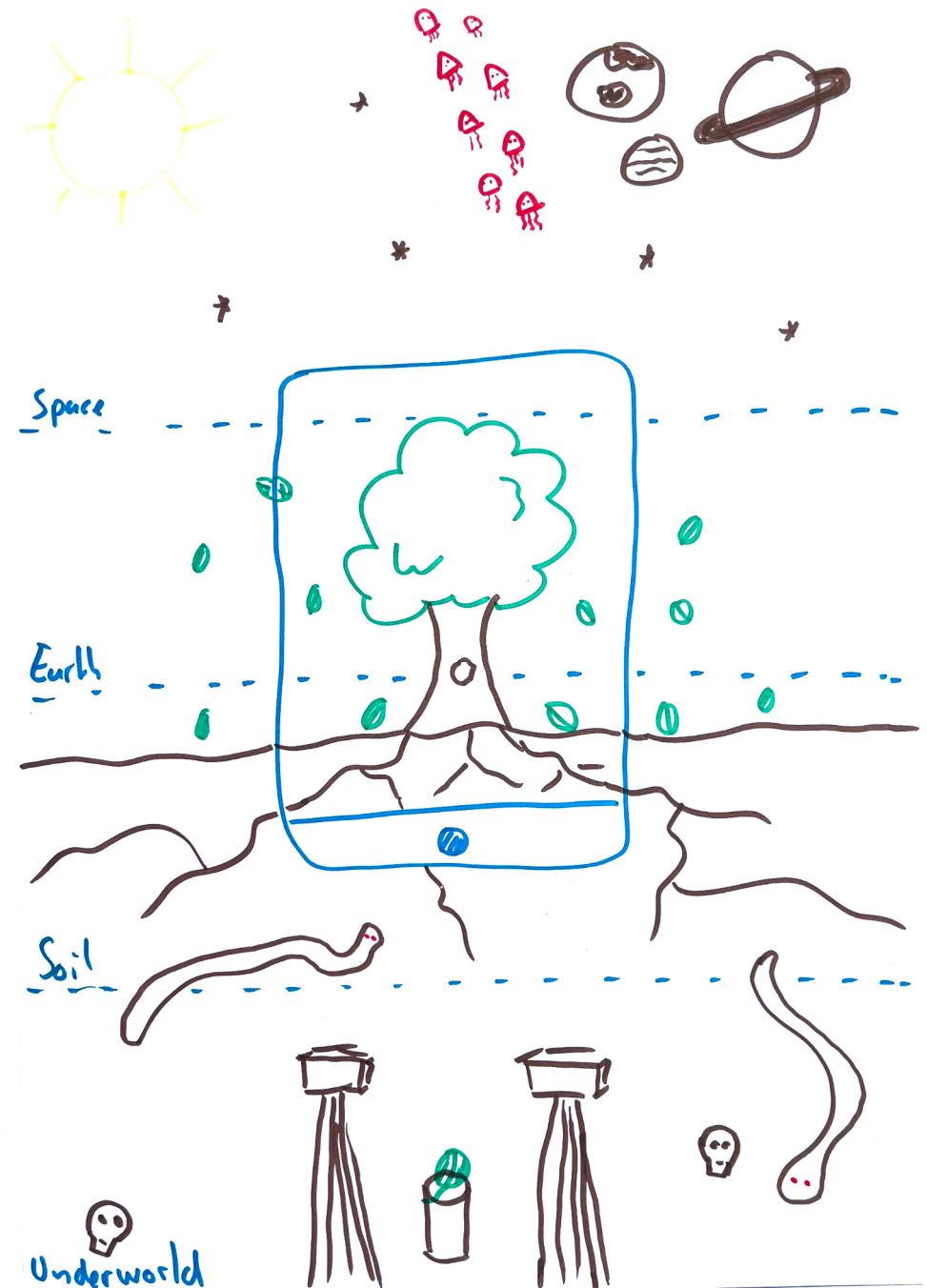
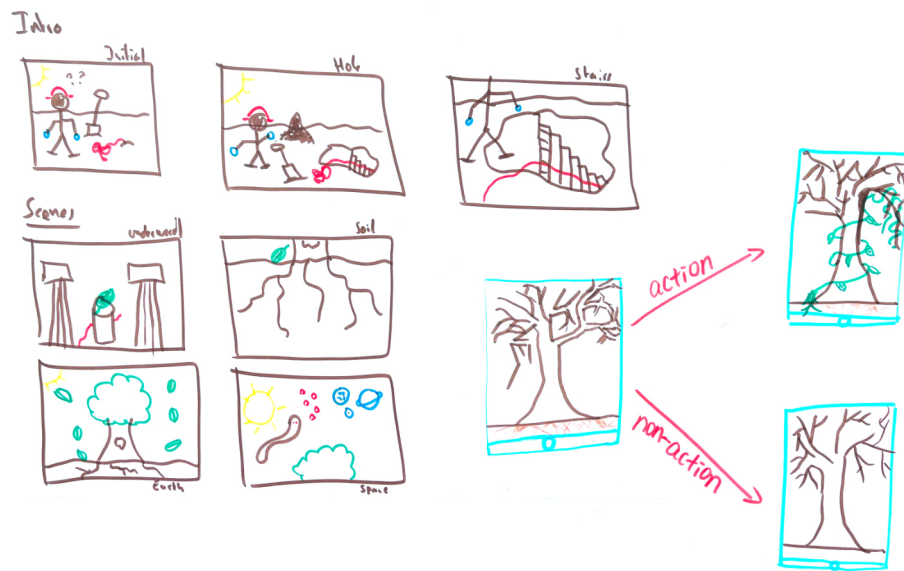
Cardboard Prototype

Our initial ecosystem was composed of four interconnected worlds:

1. Space
2. Surface
3. Soil
4. Underworld

While tending the Cimetière des Rois, Hans discovered a red thread inspired by the exhibition scenography. Following it through these worlds, he encountered a series of situations in which he had to decide whether to act upon his environment or simply let events unfold.

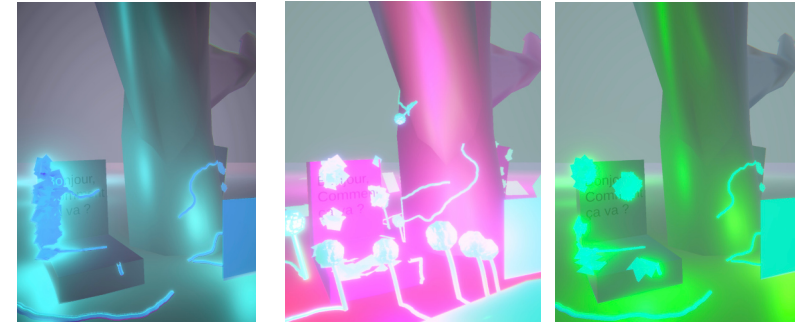
The sketches helped us align on the project's core ideas, revealing that the experience contained too many concepts and needed to be simplified.



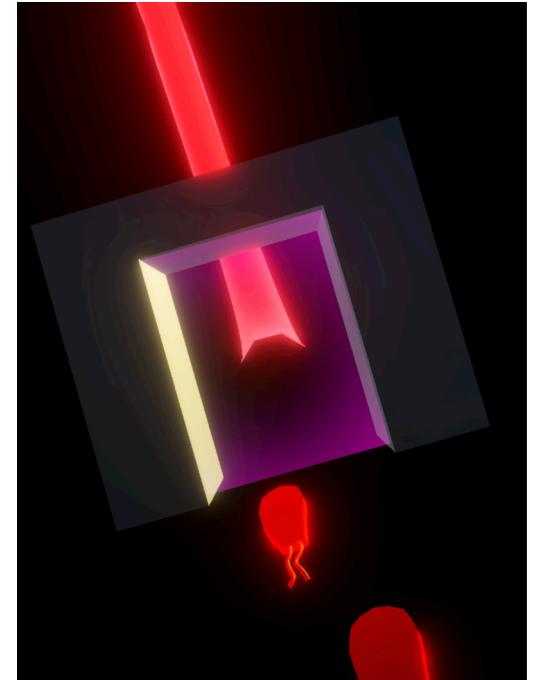
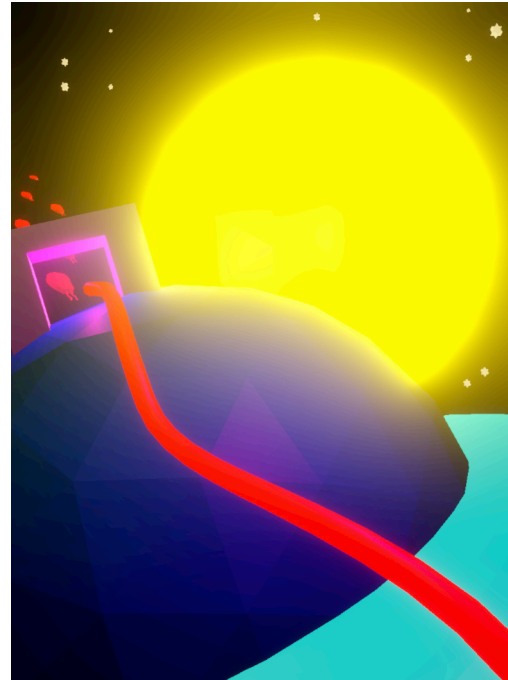
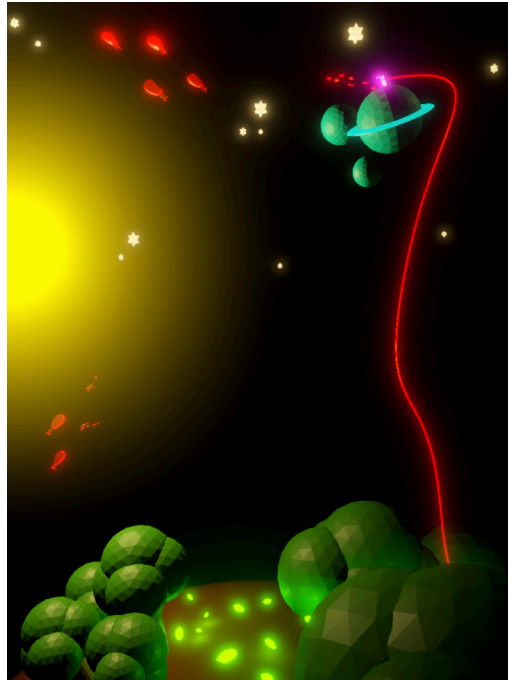
Greybox Prototype

We explored how players could navigate between different worlds and how a red thread could guide them through the experience.

As the project evolved, the red thread gradually transformed into a root, grounding the experience in the ecological cycles of the cemetery. Through iteration, we simplified the experience to a single view built around a few essential elements, allowing us to focus on depth rather than quantity.



The prototype also explored various interactions, such as cleaning moss from gravestones, growing flowers, and encouraging ivy to spread across the cemetery.



User Tests

The testing and feedback phases highlighted six key lessons:

1. The experience attempted to communicate too many ideas at once, combining multiple concepts, systems, and layers.
2. Interactions lacked immediate feedback. Players needed clearer visual cues to discover mechanics such as accelerating time or creating wind.
3. The cemetery setting was not sufficiently legible. Many players did not immediately recognize the « Cimetière des Rois ».
4. The consequences of player actions were not always visible, making it difficult to understand how choices affected the ecosystem and subsequent cycles.
5. The experience lacked a clear beginning and ending, leaving players unsure of their role and progression.
6. Contextual narration could strengthen understanding. Integrating Verena's voice as an in-game guide could help reveal the ecological consequences of player actions and make the cemetery's cycles more legible.



